

Study 1

Generated on: November 13, 2025

Core Details

Created On:	November 13, 2025
Target Audience:	Students aged 18 to 25 from the Faculty of Mathematics at the Autonomous University of Yucatán who live in Mérida, Yucatán, Mexico.
Research Goal:	Gather opinions about the use of a carpooling application for traveling between the university and a point near their home, including their willingness to pay and the safety factors that would influence their decision to use the app.
Study Strategy:	Dynamic Interview
Language:	english

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Executive Summary

Brief description: Summary of core findings about students' willingness to use a carpooling app for trips between campus and home, focusing on safety, cost, and route convenience. These students prioritize trust and predictable costs, and they adapt behavior (wait, choose bus, or coordinate with peers) when the app doesn't meet those needs.

Key Insights

1. Safety and trust are the primary adoption drivers

- Summary: Verified driver profiles, high ratings/reviews, live-tracking, and easy emergency contact are decisive for students considering carpooling. Trust mechanisms outweigh novelty for many.
- Impact: Because safety concerns are central, an app that visibly and reliably demonstrates verification, post-ride feedback, and real-time monitoring will gain users faster. Students will avoid services that feel opaque even if cheaper; conversely, well-communicated safety features reduce perceived risk of riding with strangers and increase repeat usage. Building social proof (recent positive reviews, visible trip histories) is essential to convert cautious users and reduce reliance on acquaintances.
- Variations: Concerns intensify during late-night trips or bad weather (higher willingness to pay for safety). Some users prefer rides with acquaintances when possible; others will accept strangers if verification and reviews are strong. The depth of scrutiny (number of reviews checked, attention to recent negative patterns) varies by individual.

2. Price sensitivity relative to bus fares shapes demand

- Summary: Students compare carpool prices to the bus and are price-sensitive; reasonable parity with bus costs or discounts for frequent use make carpooling attractive.
- Impact: Cost-competitiveness is a gatekeeper for regular adoption. Low-income students weigh convenience and safety against routine bus fares; if carpool pricing is consistently higher without clear added value, users revert to buses, bikes, or waiting strategies. Pricing models that include transparent cost-sharing, student discounts, or loyalty incentives can shift modal choice and encourage habitual use while preserving perceived fairness and predictability.

- Variations: Willingness to pay increases in adverse conditions (rain, late-night) or for longer/complex routes. Conversely, surge pricing or unexpected fees push students to delay travel, wait in safe public places, or choose alternate modes.

3. Route availability and scheduling convenience determine practical usability

- Summary: Students need routes that closely match origin/destination and schedules that align with classes and study sessions; limited matching leads to fallback on buses or informal carpooling via WhatsApp.
- Impact: Even with strong safety and fair pricing, insufficient route density or poor timing will constrain adoption. An app must prioritize fine-grained pickup/drop options, flexible scheduling, and efficient matching algorithms to compete with public transit frequency. Integrations for student group coordination (e.g., study-group pooling, scheduled recurring rides) and features that reduce detours will increase perceived convenience and conversion from habitual modes like biking or bus.
- Variations: Some students accept small detours for a reliable, cheaper ride; others require near-exact route matches. Coordination habits (organizing via WhatsApp) show demand for in-app group features for late study sessions and club events.

Relevant Quotes

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

"The idea of sharing costs and having a verified driver appealed to me, especially since safety features like live-tracking and emergency contacts are important to me."

Itzel Balam Pech:

"When the prices dropped, I felt relieved and a bit triumphant."

Key Takeaways

- Prioritize visible safety and trust features (driver verification, live-tracking, emergency contact, recent reviews) alongside transparent, bus-competitive pricing to drive adoption among these students.
- Unexpected but actionable insight: students will delay travel or use intermediate public spaces to avoid surge pricing—indicating strong price elasticity and an opportunity for time-based discounts or wait-list features to capture demand.

User Transportation Preferences

Brief description: How these students choose between biking, bus, rideshare, and informal carpools — balancing safety, cost, convenience, and social familiarity.

Key Insights

1. Modal choice is situational and cost-driven

- Summary: Students switch modes depending on distance, weather, time of day, and price; bikes and buses are default low-cost options, while rideshares are chosen when safety or convenience justify higher cost.
- Impact: An app must position itself as a clearly better alternative to the bus/bike in specific scenarios (bad weather, late nights, long/complex routes). Pricing should be transparent and competitive with bus fares for routine trips, while also offering premium value during riskier conditions. Without clear situational advantages, students revert to habitual, cheaper modes, limiting the app's adoption to occasional use rather than routine commuting.
- Variations:
 - Bad weather and late-night travel increase willingness to pay for rideshares.
 - Short, predictable trips favor biking; longer or less frequent trips favor buses unless a well-priced carpool aligns closely.

2. Safety and familiarity influence willingness to ride with strangers

- Summary: Students prefer acquaintances or organized group rides; when riding with strangers, they heavily rely on driver verification, ratings, and in-app safety tools to feel comfortable.
- Impact: Trust mechanisms directly affect adoption: visible verification badges, high-quality reviews, and live-tracking can convert cautious users who otherwise only accept rides from friends. The app should make safety signals prominent at booking time and allow simple ways to share trip info with contacts. If these signals are weak or hidden, students will avoid strangers and stick to social coordination channels like WhatsApp or campus carpools.
- Variations:
 - Some will never ride with strangers without multiple corroborating safety cues.
 - Others will accept strangers if incentives (price, faster route) outweigh perceived risks.

3. Coordination and scheduling features are essential for routine use

- Summary: Students coordinate group travel (study sessions, club events) via WhatsApp and expect predictable scheduling; inconsistent route matches and limited availability push them back to public transit or informal carpools.
- Impact: To become a habitual option, the app must support recurring rides, group bookings, and flexible pickup points that mirror how students already organize travel. Features that simplify syncing multiple riders, allow scheduling in advance, or integrate with student groups will reduce friction and replace off-platform coordination. Poor matching or inflexible scheduling will confine the app to one-off use and fail to capture group-driven demand.
- Variations:
 - Some accept small detours for reliable rides; others require near-exact pickups.
 - Demand spikes around late study sessions and events, so targeted scheduling tools matter more for certain time windows.

Relevant Quotes

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

"Costs and convenience play a big role, given my budget as a student."

Itzel Balam Pech:

"I decided to take a rideshare instead."

Key Takeaways

- Design for situational value: emphasize safety and convenience during bad weather/late hours and offer bus-competitive pricing for routine commutes.
- Surprising insight: students already delay travel (wait in public spaces, monitor prices) or use ad-hoc group coordination instead of paying more — indicating strong price sensitivity and an opportunity for time-based offers and built-in group scheduling.

Safety Concerns and Features

Brief description: Safety and trust mechanisms are decisive factors for students considering a carpooling app; features that communicate driver credibility and enable real-time oversight reduce perceived risk and increase adoption.

Key Insights

1. Driver verification, ratings and reviews are make-or-break

- Summary: Students heavily rely on verified IDs, visible ratings, and recent reviews to assess driver trustworthiness before booking. Poor or inconsistent feedback deters use even if price and route are attractive.
- Impact: An app must prioritize clear, prominent verification cues and an easy-to-read review history to convert cautious users. Without these, students default to buses, bikes, or acquaintances, limiting the app to sporadic use. Trust signals should be updated in real time (recent rides, recent reviews) and presented at booking to lower friction; otherwise perceived liability and social risk will suppress adoption among budget-conscious students.
- Variations:
- Higher scrutiny for late-night rides or longer trips.
- Some users require many corroborating reviews; others accept fewer if the profile shows consistent recent activity.

2. Real-time tracking and emergency features reduce anxiety

- Summary: Live GPS tracking, an accessible emergency contact/button, and the ability to share trip details are core expectations for comfort when riding with strangers. These features convert abstract safety promises into tangible reassurance.
- Impact: Offering robust live-tracking and a one-tap emergency/reporting flow can materially increase willingness to ride with non-acquaintances, particularly after dark or in bad weather. Students value being able to share trip status with friends/family and see an active trace of the route; this lowers perceived personal risk and increases the app's credibility versus informal or anonymous alternatives. Investing in these features also reduces reputational risk for the platform when incidents occur.
- Variations:

- Some users want automatic alerts to a trusted contact; others prefer manual sharing.
- Expectations for responsiveness (how quickly support responds) vary with time of day.

3. Preference for social familiarity and in-app group controls

- Summary: Many students prefer riding with acquaintances; when sharing with strangers, they expect features that mimic social vetting—group booking, recurring shared rides, or verified affiliation with campus groups.
- Impact: Integrating group coordination tools (group invites, recurring rides for study sessions, verified student-group badges) can capture demand that currently organizes off-app via WhatsApp. These features lower the social friction of sharing a car with others and create network effects that increase route density and safety perception. If the app fails to support easy group scheduling, students will continue to rely on informal channels and public transit.
- Variations:
 - Some accept strangers if driver signals are strong; others will only join rides initiated by a known peer.
 - Demand for group features spikes around late study sessions and club events.

Relevant Quotes

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

"Reviews and driver ratings are crucial for me. I rely on them heavily to ensure safety and trust."

Itzel Balam Pech:

"I checked the driver's ratings before booking, as I'm always a bit cautious about late-night travel."

Key Takeaways

- Make safety visible and immediate: prominent verification badges, up-to-date reviews, live-tracking, easy emergency contact, and trip-sharing should be core UX elements to drive adoption.
- Unexpected insight: students treat the app as a social system—features that enable in-app group coordination or campus-affiliated verification can substitute for personal familiarity and significantly expand acceptable rider pools.

Cost Considerations and Willingness to Pay

Brief description: How price influences mode choice and frequency of carpool app use — students weigh fares against bus costs, situational needs (weather, time), and perceived value from safety and convenience.

Key Insights

1. Price is a gatekeeper; bus parity is the benchmark

- Summary: Students compare carpool fares directly to local bus costs and expect competitive pricing. If carpooling isn't at least close in price to the bus, they revert to buses or bikes for routine trips.
- Impact: Because many students have tight budgets, the app must present pricing that feels fair versus existing public transit. Persistent higher fares will confine the service to occasional, situational use (bad weather, late-night) rather than daily commuting. Pricing that matches or slightly undercuts bus fares — or clearly justifies a premium with added safety/convenience — will be far more likely to convert habitual riders and build regular demand among low-income students.
- Variations: Willingness to pay more rises for late-night or long routes, but for short routine trips students demand near-bus parity. Some prioritize predictability over absolute low cost and will accept a small premium for transparent, stable fares.

2. Willingness to pay is context-dependent and elastic

- Summary: Students are price-sensitive but accept higher prices for safety, bad weather, or complex routes; they also delay booking when fares surge. Emotional state (stress, urgency) affects willingness to pay.
- Impact: Dynamic pricing without clear justification risks losing users to waiting strategies or alternatives. The app should use context-aware offers (e.g., small premiums for guaranteed safety features at night) and avoid opaque surge spikes. Transparent, time- or condition-based pricing (and visible reasons for higher fares) will maintain trust and capture demand during high-value windows without alienating budget-conscious users.

- Variations: Some students will tolerate temporary surge pricing if the trip is urgent; others will wait in public spaces or use cafés until prices normalize. The threshold for "acceptable premium" differs by individual urgency and available alternatives.

3. Discounts, cost-sharing and loyalty drive repeat use

- Summary: Students respond positively to visible cost-sharing, student discounts, introductory promotions, and loyalty incentives that lower per-ride cost over time.
- Impact: Incentives that reduce effective cost — group discounts, recurring-ride plans, referral credits, or student passes — can shift one-off trial behavior into habitual commuting. These mechanisms also encourage group bookings that improve route density and driver availability, creating a virtuous cycle. Without such programs, even a functional, safe app may struggle to retain regular users who default to cheaper public options.
- Variations: Some prefer straightforward per-ride discounts; others value subscription-like bundles for frequent travel. Group cost-sharing tools are especially valued when students organize rides after evening activities.

Relevant Quotes

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

"A fair price would be one that's competitive with the cost of taking the bus for a similar route."

Itzel Balam Pech:

"I was also a bit worried about the cost since I try to save money where I can."

Key Takeaways

- Actionable: Adopt bus-competitive baseline fares plus transparent, contextual premiums (clearly labeled for night/weather/safety), and offer student-focused discounts or group-sharing incentives to convert occasional users into regular riders.
- Surprising: Students will actively delay travel (wait in cafés, monitor prices) rather than accept seemingly unfair surge fares — showing strong price elasticity and an opportunity for timed discounts or waitlist/capture features.

Influence of Reviews and Ratings

Brief description: Reviews and driver ratings are primary trust signals for these students; they use them to assess safety, punctuality, and overall reliability before booking a ride.

Key Insights

1. Reviews and ratings are the top pre-booking filter

- Summary: Students scan ratings and recent reviews first to decide whether to consider a driver; high ratings provide immediate reassurance while negative patterns prompt avoidance.
- Impact: Because reviews act as a quick trust shortcut, presenting clear, recent, and easily scannable feedback at booking time will materially increase conversion. If reviews are sparse or show recurring issues, students skip the option entirely and revert to buses, bikes, or familiar peers. Platforms must encourage frequent, specific feedback and surface summary signals (e.g., punctuality, safety badges) to reduce friction and build confidence among budget-sensitive users.
- Variations: Some students require many corroborating reviews before trusting a driver; others accept fewer reviews if the driver shows recent activity and verification badges.

2. Content matters: punctuality, driving safety, and behavior dominate

- Summary: Students focus on concrete review topics—safe driving, punctuality, respectful behavior, and vehicle condition—rather than generic praise. Specific negative mentions (e.g., cancellations, unsafe driving) are deal-breakers.
- Impact: Detailed, structured reviews (tagged by topic) help users make faster, better-informed decisions. Highlighting metrics like cancellation rate, average arrival time, and safety incidents can prevent distrust and reduce time spent vetting drivers. Platforms that prompt riders to rate those key dimensions will create more actionable profiles that directly address students' primary concerns, increasing likelihood of booking—especially for late-night or weather-sensitive trips.

- Variations: Weight given to each topic shifts by context: safety details weigh more at night, punctuality matters more for scheduled pickups, and vehicle condition matters more on longer trips.

3. Reviews interact with other trust signals and context

- Summary: Reviews are necessary but not always sufficient; students combine them with verification badges, live-tracking, and contextual factors (time of day, weather) to form a final judgment.
- Impact: An integrated trust presentation—showing reviews alongside verification status, recent ride history, and active live-tracking—amplifies confidence more than any single element. During high-risk contexts (late-night, rain), positive reviews plus visible verification and trip-sharing options significantly raise willingness to pay. Platforms should design the UX to show these signals together at decision points; otherwise, even good reviews may not overcome lack of visible verification or poor situational cues.
- Variations: Some users will accept weaker review signals if strong verification and live-tracking are present; others demand all signals aligned before booking.

Relevant Quotes

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

"When I check reviews, I focus on comments about punctuality, driving safety, and the overall experience."

Itzel Balam Pech:

"If I see comments about unsafe driving, lateness, or any mentions of inappropriate behavior, I definitely avoid booking with that driver."

Key Takeaways

- Actionable: Surface concise, topic-tagged review summaries (safety, punctuality, cancellations) alongside verification badges and recent-ride indicators at booking to speed trust decisions and increase conversions.
- Surprising: Even with high ratings, students still hesitate without contextual signals (recent activity, live-tracking)—reviews alone don't guarantee trust in risky situations.

Challenges with Current Transportation Options

Brief description: Key frictions students face with biking, buses, rideshares, and informal carpools—these frictions drive mode-switching, delays, and reliance on off-platform coordination.

Key Insights

1. Poor route matching and infrequent availability

- Summary: Students frequently find that carpool or rideshare options don't match their exact origin/destination or schedule, forcing them to use buses, bikes, or coordinate informal rides instead.
- Impact: When route density and scheduling don't align with students' class times and home locations, the perceived convenience of app-based carpooling collapses. Even with strong safety and fair pricing, lack of close matches makes the service impractical for routine commuting. This lowers retention and confines app use to occasional, situational trips; it also encourages students to continue organizing rides via WhatsApp or campus networks, which keeps demand fragmented and reduces predictable matching for drivers.
- Variations: Some students accept small detours for a reliable, cheaper ride; others require near-exact matches. Demand is higher around late study sessions and club events, where group coordination could increase viability if supported.

2. Price volatility leads to delay behaviors and stress

- Summary: Surge pricing or opaque fare increases prompt students to delay travel, wait in public places, or choose cheaper alternatives rather than pay unexpectedly higher fares.
- Impact: Strong price sensitivity among low-income students means opaque dynamic pricing undermines trust and reduces bookings. Instead of converting urgent demand, surge pricing often causes students to wait (e.g., in cafés) or revert to public transit — behaviors that decrease platform revenue and weaken perceived reliability. Transparent, contextual pricing or targeted discounts could capture that deferred demand without alienating price-conscious users.

- Variations: Willingness to accept higher fares rises in emergencies, bad weather, or late-night scenarios; some students will tolerate short surges if justified, while others will always wait for normal rates.

3. Safety concerns and limited social familiarity reduce uptake

- Summary: Fear of riding with strangers, especially at night or in poor conditions, pushes students toward acquaintances, buses, or cycling unless strong trust signals exist.
- Impact: Safety is a gating factor: without clear verification, recent positive reviews, and real-time monitoring, students avoid strangers and prefer familiar arrangements. This reduces the pool of potential matches and makes scaling difficult. Apps that don't foreground verification, easy trip-sharing, and emergency options will struggle to convert users who prioritize perceived personal safety over marginal time savings or cost benefits.
- Variations: Some students will ride with strangers if multiple trust signals align (verification + live-tracking + strong reviews); others will accept strangers only if the ride is initiated by someone they know or via a campus-affiliated group.

Relevant Quotes

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

"However, there weren't any options that matched my exact needs, so I ended up taking the bus instead."

Itzel Balam Pech:

"Instead of booking, I headed to a nearby café, did some reading, and monitored the prices."

Key Takeaways

- Most important: Improve route matching, predictable scheduling (recurring/group rides), and transparent pricing to convert occasional interest into regular use.
- Most surprising: Students will often delay travel and wait in public spaces rather than pay unclear surge prices—showing high price elasticity and an opportunity for trust-building, time-based offers, or waitlist capture features.

Surprising Insight

Brief description: One counterintuitive pattern emerged: students often prioritize predictable cost and social familiarity over immediate convenience — they will delay travel, coordinate socially, or accept minor inconveniences rather than pay opaque premiums or ride with unknown drivers.

Key Insights

1. Students actively delay travel to avoid opaque surge pricing

- Summary: Rather than accept unexpectedly high fares, students will wait in safe public places (cafés), monitor prices, and book only when rates normalize.
- Impact: This behavior reduces short-term bookings during peak pricing and undermines the effectiveness of dynamic pricing as a revenue lever. It also signals strong price elasticity among low-income students: perceived unfair price spikes not only cut conversions but teach users to game the system (wait for lower prices). Platforms that rely on opaque surges risk long-term trust erosion and lost demand during critical windows (late night, bad weather).
- Variations: Some students will wait only if they can stay safe and productive (e.g., café nearby); others will accept surges if urgency or safety concerns are high.

2. Predictability and social signals can substitute for personal familiarity

- Summary: Students are willing to ride with strangers if the app provides strong, predictable safety and social cues (verification badges, recent reviews, campus-group affiliations); these cues can replace the comfort of riding with acquaintances.
- Impact: Designing features that replicate social vetting (verified student groups, recurring group rides, explicit driver activity logs) can expand acceptable rider pools and improve match rates. This means in-app community and verification mechanisms can create the same confidence that used to require a personal connection, increasing practical availability without relying solely on organic social networks.
- Variations: Some students demand multiple corroborating signals (reviews + live-tracking + group badge); others will accept one strong cue (e.g., campus affiliation).

3. Predictability outranks marginal convenience for routine commutes

- Summary: For regular trips, students value stable, transparent pricing and reliable timelines more than slightly faster or more comfortable options with unpredictable costs.
- Impact: To win habitual use, an app must emphasize predictability (flat or capped fares, scheduled rides, clear cancellation policies) over occasional speed advantages. Predictability reduces cognitive load and financial anxiety for students on tight budgets, increasing loyalty. Conversely, a service offering marginally faster trips but variable costs will struggle to displace low-cost habitual modes like buses or biking.
- Variations: In urgent or high-risk situations (heavy rain, late night), students temporarily prioritize speed and safety over predictability, accepting premiums when justified.

Relevant Quotes

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

"I wanted to compare the pricing and see if the drivers had good reviews, as I always prioritize safety and transparency."

Itzel Balam Pech:

"I felt a mix of frustration and concern."

Key Takeaways

- Most important: Prioritize predictable, transparent pricing and strong social-verification features (campus/group badges, recent-activity indicators) to convert students who otherwise delay travel or stick to informal coordination.
- Most surprising: Students will routinely postpone travel in safe locations to avoid opaque surges — showing trust in their ability to time the market and revealing an opportunity for waitlist captures, timed discounts, or guaranteed-price scheduling to recover deferred demand.

Suggested Follow-Up Question

Primary question: - "What specific combination of features (exact price range compared to the bus, required driver-verification cues, and scheduling options) would make you choose a carpooling app for regular campus-home commutes instead of waiting or using the bus?"

Rationale: - This single question targets the three decisive factors (price, safety signals, and scheduling/route fit) and forces respondents to state concrete thresholds and trade-offs rather than abstract preferences.

Suggested prompts to probe further: - "What exact fare (in pesos) relative to your usual bus cost would feel fair for a regular one-way trip?" - "Which verification elements (ID badge, X number of recent positive reviews, live-tracking, ability to share trip) are absolute requirements versus nice-to-have?" - "Would you pay a small premium to guarantee no detours or a fixed pickup time? If so, how much?" - "In surge situations, what conditions (late-night, heavy rain, urgency) would make you accept higher fares, and by what factor?" - "How often would you use a recurring/pooled ride if a student-discount or subscription reduced cost by Y%?"

Interviews

SyntheticUsers

Interview #1

María Fernanda Xiu Canché

Personal Information

Age	24
Location	Mérida, Yucatán, Mexico
Profession	Undergraduate Mathematics Student, Faculty of Mathematics (UADY); part-time math tutor

Dynamic Parameters

Technology Usage	High — frequent use of smartphone, laptop, educational apps and forums; uses payment apps and occasionally beta-tests new services
Transportation Habits	Owns a bicycle for short trips, uses ADO bus for longer routes; sometimes accepts rides from acquaintances; would use a carpool app if cost-sharing is transparent and routes match closely
Social Influence	Moderate — tutors classmates and posts solutions in student groups; trusted by tutees
Income Level	Low — income from tutoring and family allowance
Safety Perception	High — requires verified driver profile, clear pricing, live-tracking and emergency contact
Study Habits	Flexible, late-night coding/problem solving, studies with peers before exams, uses practice contests

Personality Traits

Openness To Experience	5
Conscientiousness	5
Extraversion	2
Agreeableness	4
Neuroticism	3

Interview Transcript

Interviewer:

When was the last time you considered using a carpooling app for your commute, and what influenced that decision?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

I last thought about using a carpooling app a few weeks ago. I usually ride my bike for short trips, but I was considering a longer journey. The idea of sharing costs and having a verified driver appealed to me, especially since safety features like live-tracking and emergency contacts are important to me. Plus, if I could find a route that matches my destination closely, it would save some time compared to the bus. Costs and convenience play a big role, given my budget as a student.

Interviewer:

What did you do right after considering it, and why?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

After considering it, I checked a couple of carpooling apps to see if there were any available rides that fit my schedule and route. I wanted to compare the pricing and see if the drivers had good reviews, as I always prioritize safety and transparency. However, there weren't any options that matched my exact needs, so I ended up taking the bus instead. The flexibility and frequency of the bus made it a more suitable option at the time.

Interviewer:

What role did reviews and driver ratings play in your decision process?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

Reviews and driver ratings are crucial for me. I rely on them heavily to ensure safety and trust. Knowing that other users had good experiences makes me feel more comfortable about the potential ride. If a driver has a lot of positive feedback, it gives me confidence in their reliability. On the flip side, if I notice any negative patterns in reviews, I'm likely to look for alternatives. It's about feeling secure and assured about the journey.

Interviewer:

What do you typically look for in reviews before deciding to use a carpooling service?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

When I check reviews, I focus on comments about punctuality, driving safety, and the overall experience. It's important to me that the driver is described as friendly and reliable. I also look for mentions of how well the app's described features, like live tracking and emergency contacts, worked. If users mention transparent pricing and clear communication, that's a huge plus. Essentially, I want to know that past riders felt safe and satisfied.

Interviewer:

What would make you switch from your usual transportation method to a carpooling app more consistently?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

I'd switch more consistently if I could find reliable routes that align closely with my destinations, at a cost that fits my budget. Consistently high driver ratings and positive reviews would also reassure me about safety. If the app offered dynamic features, like more flexible ride options or discounts for frequent users, that would be appealing too. Ultimately, it would have to combine convenience, safety, and affordability better than my usual methods.

Interviewer:

How do you feel about sharing rides with acquaintances versus strangers when using a carpooling app?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

I'm generally more comfortable sharing rides with acquaintances because there's a level of familiarity and trust. With strangers, I rely heavily on the app's safety features, reviews, and ratings to feel at ease. Sharing with strangers can be a bit nerve-wracking, so ensuring the app has strong security measures in place is crucial for me. Clear communication and a trustworthy driver profile can help mitigate those concerns.

Interviewer:

What would be your main concerns, if any, when considering carpooling with strangers?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

My main concerns would be safety and trust. Sharing a ride with someone I don't know naturally brings apprehensions about their driving skills and personal behavior. I'd worry about punctuality and whether the driver respects the agreed route and stop points. Privacy is another consideration, as being in a confined space with strangers can feel a bit uncomfortable. So, I'd heavily rely on the app's safety features and user reviews to address those worries.

Interviewer:

What factors would make you feel more secure when carpooling with strangers?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

To feel more secure, I'd need features like driver verification, live tracking, and an easy way to contact someone in an emergency. Comprehensive reviews from other users help build trust, and knowing there's transparent pricing adds to that. I'd also appreciate an option to share my trip details with a friend or family member. These factors together would make me feel more at ease about carpooling with strangers.

Interviewer:

What would be a fair price for you to regularly use a carpooling app, compared to your typical transportation costs?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

A fair price would be one that's competitive with the cost of taking the bus for a similar route. Since my budget is tight, I'd consider it reasonable if the carpooling app offered rates that make it affordable to use at least a couple of times a week without cutting into other essentials. It should ideally offer discounts or incentives for frequent rides or shared journeys. Balancing affordability with reliability would make it a viable option for me.

Interviewer:

What would encourage you to try a carpooling app again in the future?

María Fernanda Xiu Canché:

I'd be encouraged to try a carpooling app again if I saw improvements in route availability that match my destinations more closely. Seeing consistently high reviews for drivers would instill confidence in the safety and reliability of the service. Offers like introductory discounts or promotions could also entice me, as they'd make trying the service less of a financial risk. Enhancements in user experience, like an intuitive interface and seamless booking process, would also help. If these elements align, I'd definitely consider giving it another shot.

Interview #2

Itzel Balam Pech

Personal Information

Age	20
Location	Mérida, Yucatán, Mexico
Profession	Undergraduate Mathematics Student, Faculty of Mathematics (UADY)

Dynamic Parameters

Technology Usage	High — daily use of smartphone, campus platforms, WhatsApp and Google Drive
Transportation Habits	Walks or cycles to campus; occasional rideshare/ taxi home in evenings; open to carpool if scheduled and vetted
Social Influence	Moderate — active in study groups and math club, trusted among peers
Income Level	Low — family support, student stipend / part-time research assistant income
Safety Perception	Medium — concerned about late-night travel; values verified IDs and driver ratings
Study Habits	Prefers structured study schedule, morning problem sets, studies in library groups twice weekly

Personality Traits

Openness To Experience	4
Conscientiousness	4
Extraversion	3
Agreeableness	4
Neuroticism	3

Interview Transcript

Interviewer:

Think about the most recent time you needed to travel from the university to your home area or vice versa - what happened during that trip?

Itzel Balam Pech:

I recently had to get home from the university after an evening study session. Since I usually cycle, I was hoping to ride my bike, but it started raining pretty heavily. So, I decided to take a rideshare instead.

I checked the driver's ratings before booking, as I'm always a bit cautious about late-night travel. It was a bit awkward getting my bike into the car, but the driver was helpful. During the ride, I mostly went over some of the math problems in my head that we worked on during the study group.

The trip itself was pretty uneventful, but I felt a sense of relief once I got home. I like to keep a structured study schedule, so the rain kind of messed with my plans, but it worked out in the end.

Interviewer:

What went through your mind when you first realized you'd need to change your transportation plan that evening?

Itzel Balam Pech:

When I saw the rain, my first thought was, "Oh no, not again," because riding in the rain isn't fun or safe. I felt a mix of frustration and concern. Frustration because I like sticking to my plan of biking, and concern about finding a safe, reliable rideshare at that hour.

I quickly went into problem-solving mode, checking the rideshare app and looking for drivers with good ratings. I was also a bit worried about the cost since I try to save money where I can. But in the end, safety took priority, and I felt a bit more at ease once I had a plan.

Interviewer:

What specific things did you check about the driver before deciding to book with them?

Itzel Balam Pech:

I focused mainly on the driver's ratings and the number of trips they've completed. High ratings with a decent number of reviews make me feel more comfortable, especially for late-night rides. I also look at recent reviews to see if there are any recurring issues. Verified IDs and a solid profile picture help too, as they add to my sense of security.

Interviewer:

When you read through those reviews, what kinds of comments or patterns make you decide against a particular driver?

Itzel Balam Pech:

If I see comments about unsafe driving, lateness, or any mentions of inappropriate behavior, I definitely avoid booking with that driver. Negative patterns like a lot of cancellations or complaints about the car's condition can be deal-breakers too. I also pay attention to how recent the negative reviews are; if there's a bad trend, I steer clear.

Interviewer:

When you're evaluating a rideshare, what makes you feel the cost is worth it versus when you think it's too expensive?

Itzel Balam Pech:

I consider the context, like the time of day and weather. Late at night or during bad weather, I'm willing to pay more for safety and convenience. If the route is particularly long or complicated, I'll also weigh that in. If the cost feels high but justified by these factors, it's worth it.

However, if it's just a regular day with okay weather and the price is much higher than usual without any clear reason like surge pricing, then it feels too expensive. I try to balance safety and budget as much as I can.

Interviewer:

How do you typically decide what amount is "too much" for a ride - do you have a specific number in mind or does it depend on something else?

Itzel Balam Pech:

I don't have a specific number in mind, but it depends on a few factors like distance, time of day, and my current budget. Usually, if the fare seems significantly higher than normal without any clear justification, that's when it feels like too much. I also compare it to what a similar ride would cost at another time when prices are stable. If it exceeds what I usually spend on transportation for the week, I reconsider.

Interviewer:

What happened the last time you decided a ride was too expensive and chose not to take it?

Itzel Balam Pech:

The last time I decided a ride was too expensive was during a weekend evening. There was a sudden surge in prices due to high demand. I thought about it for a while and ultimately decided to wait it out. Instead of booking, I headed to a nearby café, did some reading, and monitored the prices.

After a while, the rates dropped to a more reasonable level, and I booked the ride. It meant getting home a bit later than planned, but it was worth it to save money. I also felt a bit more in control by waiting, rather than paying the higher fare impulsively.

Interviewer:

When you were waiting at the café monitoring prices, what were you thinking about during that time?

Itzel Balam Pech:

While waiting, I was trying to balance the cost and my safety concerns. I kept thinking about when I'd feel comfortable enough to book and whether it was worth the wait. I was also a bit worried about the time, hoping the prices would drop sooner rather than later.

While there, I used the time to do a bit of reading for class, which helped me feel productive. I checked the app periodically, and I felt a sense of relief and accomplishment when the prices finally went down. Waiting wasn't ideal, but it paid off in the end, and I felt like I made a smart decision.

Interviewer:

What emotions did you experience when you saw the prices drop back down to normal levels?

Itzel Balam Pech:

When the prices dropped, I felt relieved and a bit triumphant. It was satisfying to see my patience pay off. There was also a sense of validation in my decision to wait it out rather than spending more than I was comfortable with. It reassured me that sometimes taking a bit more time to assess a situation can lead to better outcomes.

Interviewer:

What other situations, if any, have you found yourself in where you needed to coordinate transportation with other people from university?

Itzel Balam Pech:

I often carpool with classmates after study groups or club meetings, especially if we're finishing late. Coordinating who needs a ride and syncing our schedules can be a bit challenging, but it's a helpful way to save money and feel safer. We typically use WhatsApp to organize everything.

Once, after a math conference on campus, we decided to share a ride back. It required some back-and-forth to decide on pickup points and times, but it worked out. It's nice knowing others are involved, so if there's a delay or issue, we're all in it together. Plus, it's a good opportunity to chat and decompress after a long day.

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